

The **Media** and the **War**

The first war shown extensively on television, Vietnam was the focus of increasingly critical coverage by the US media. As a result, many Americans lost confidence both in the Pentagon's version of events and the ability of US forces to triumph.

◀◀ BEFORE

The phenomenon of reporting from the battlefield was not new to the Vietnam War—nor was the use of photography to capture the horrors of combat.

HISTORIC PARTNERSHIP

The US media's **cozy relationship** with the military stretched back to the Civil War, when reporters began to dispatch **eyewitness stories from the battlefield**. Most of the coverage was slanted toward the "home side"—the Union or Confederacy. During World War I, General Pershing allowed reporters to be embedded with his troops on the Western Front, while World War II produced reporters such as Ernie Pyle. **War photography had an equally long history**—one of the first war photographers, Roger Fenton, took pictures during the Crimean War in 1854.

In 1960, there were more than 52 million American households with TV sets; the overwhelming majority were black-and-white units, and satellite broadcasts were still a thing of the future. Three big nationwide networks (CBS, NBC, and ABC) dominated the airwaves. News and entertainment programming was conservative and largely conformed to middle class, white American values. Nearly everyone tuned into the network news shows. Prior to US involvement in Vietnam, American TV technology and culture were relatively undeveloped.